

Hedgehogs and relatives

Order Eulipotyphla

Moonrat

Echinosorex gymnura

- ↔ 10–18 in (26–46 cm)
- 📍 SE. Asia
- ⊗ Common

The moonrat is one of a small group of mainly insectivorous mammals closely related to hedgehogs but without the spines. It has harsh, rough, coarse outer fur and a long, scaly, almost hairless tail. The moonrat hunts at night in the tropical forests of Southeast Asia, catching insects on the ground but also pursuing aquatic animals, including fish, in the water. It marks its territory with a pungent scent of ammonia, similar to that of rotting onions.

Long-eared hedgehog

Hemiechinus auritus

- ↔ 6–11 in (15–28 cm)
- 📍 S. Asia
- ⊗ Locally common

This prickly mammal is adapted for life in the desert. Its large ears act as radiators, helping it to lose excess heat, and it gets most of the water it needs from its insect food. Spending the day in its burrow, it emerges at dusk to hunt. When prey is scarce, it can become dormant, but this state rarely lasts long.

Other species

- European hedgehog
Erinaceus europaeus » p156

Shrews and moles

Order Eulipotyphla

Eurasian shrew

Sorex araneus

- ↔ 2–3 in (5–8 cm)
- 📍 Europe to N. Asia
- ⊗ Common



Also known as the common shrew, this tiny, frenetically active animal has such a fast rate of metabolism that it must eat 80–90 percent of its body weight in food every 24 hours, or it will starve. It hunts day and night, taking short rests between regular bursts of activity when it uses its long, bristly, sensitive snout to search for insects, worms, slugs, and snails. Adults are normally solitary except during a brief courtship period in spring or early fall. The common shrew is territorial—it defends itself vigorously, biting if cornered.

Eurasian water shrew

Neomys fodiens

- ↔ 3–4 in (8–10 cm)
- 📍 Europe to N. Asia
- ⊗ Common

Adapted for hunting in pools and streams, the water shrew has water-repellent outer fur and thick underfur that keeps it warm when submerged. Its back and sides are dark, but it has a white underside. It propels itself underwater with its hair-fringed hindfeet, pursuing aquatic insects, small fish, and frogs. It has venomous saliva that immobilizes the prey it seizes in its teeth. It also hunts on land for beetles and worms.

short, dense fur



Armored shrew

Scutisorex somereni

- ↔ 4–6 in (10–15 cm)
- 📍 C. to E. Africa
- ⊗ Common

This large shrew has a highly unusual spine adaptation—each backbone has interlocking flanges above, below, and on each side, making it immensely strong. The adaptation's function is unknown, but studies suggest it may help the shrew lever dead logs off the ground to get at worms hiding below.

Bicolored white-toothed shrew

Crocidura leucodon

- ↔ 2–7 in (5–18 cm)
- 📍 Europe to W. Asia
- ⊗ Common

The name of this shrew refers to the sharp divide between the brown fur of its upperparts and the creamy white underfur. It is one of a large subfamily of shrews that have white teeth; those of the other subfamily have red-tipped teeth. It hunts by night for worms and insect grubs.

Hispaniolan solenodon

Solenodon paradoxus

- ↔ 11–13 in (28–33 cm)
- 📍 Caribbean (Hispaniola)
- ⊗ Endangered

This shrewlike insectivore was first described in 1833. It hunts at night for insects and small vertebrates, half-paralyzing them with a venomous bite that it also uses for defense. It is one of just two species of solenodon, the other being found on the nearby island of Cuba.

Russian desman

Desmana moschata

- ↔ 7–9 in (18–23 cm)
- 📍 E. Europe to C. Asia
- ⊗ Vulnerable

Native to river systems to the north of the Black Sea, the desman is part of the mole family, but hunts in the water. It swims well, propelled by its webbed hindfeet and laterally flattened tail. It uses its sensitive nose to probe for aquatic insects and crayfish among the stones of the riverbed. It lives in groups, which may share a riverbank burrow.

Star-nosed mole

Condylura cristata

- ↔ 7–8 in (18–20 cm)
- 📍 E. Canada, NE. US
- ⊗ Common

The nose of this functionally blind mole ends in 22 fleshy tentacles equipped with thousands of microscopic sensory organs that are highly responsive to touch and help the mole detect prey. This mole digs a network of tunnels through the soil. It is also an excellent swimmer, and hunts mainly in the water for insects, worms, and small fish.

